Prior-art sweep v2: informed-choice preservation and the "Never Miss the Narrows" protocol

24 Oct 2026. This updates the 22 Oct sweep. Every work below was found with web search today, and its arXiv or venue page was opened or listed in the results. One citation from the earlier sweep, "Deception by Omission (2610.11351)", **could not be verified and is dropped**.

1. Verdict

The general claim ("assistants should volunteer decision-relevant information, and a short prompt can help") is **already in the literature**:

- **"Thinking Is Not Telling" (Feb 2026)** defines proactive information disclosure for user-service agents. It shows that a short disclosure instruction raises task success by about 3–5 points.
- **MASK-OFF (NeurIPS 2026 workshop)** shows that frontier models omit material facts in 46–95% of benign requests, and that one salience sentence reduces omission.

What remains distinct to our work:

1. **Timing:** re-raising a known item *at the moment of decision*, after long-horizon decay of up to 234 messages.
2. **Silent tradeoffs:** cutting a must-see to fit another goal without saying so.
3. **Self-recorded deadlines with changed dependencies:** related to prospective memory (PM-Bench), but inside a conversation.
4. **Idle-time and early-ending-day audits.**
5. **Measured costs of the fix:** over-intervention in no-nag controls, and crowding out of untargeted facts.
6. **A counterfactual replay of a real failure.**

The cost findings are consistent with PM-Bench ("more reminders do not automatically yield a better operating point") and with interruption-cost work (Horvitz; "When Help Backfires").

2. Closest work, ranked by overlap

Work	What it shows	Overlap	How we differ
Thinking Is Not Telling (Li et al., arXiv 2602.07796, Feb 2026)	Agents reason about decision-relevant facts but don't tell users. 5 disclosure categories. A disclosure prompt helps (e.g. GPT-4o pass^1 52.3 → 57.6). τ-Bench and ToolSandbox; 5 models.	**High**	Single-session service tasks, no long-horizon decay, no silent-tradeoff or idle audit, and no over-intervention controls. We test 7 models × 36 scenarios with matched no-nag controls and find the prompt's cost.
MASK-OFF (Rahman & Moeljono, NeurIPS 2026 AI4GOOD workshop)	14 of 15 models omit material facts in 46–95% of benign requests. One sentence raising salience reduces omission.	High	Single requests; harm-relevant facts. We study planning dialogues, decision timing, and costs.

Work	What it shows	Overlap	How we differ
ProactBench (arXiv 2605.09228, May 2026)	Conversational proactivity on implied needs; 16 models	High	No decision-time resurfacing, no matched nagging controls, no intervention arm.
π-Bench (arXiv 2605.14678, May 2026)	Hidden intents in long-horizon personal-assistant workflows	High	We isolate long-horizon *decay* of an item the assistant itself disclosed, and test a fix.
ATRBench, "Ask Now, Use Later" (arXiv 2605.28108, May 2026)	Agents fail to ask for unstated preferences needed later; prompting closes little	High	They study acquisition from the user. Our protocol closes much of a *disclosure and audit* gap. We position this contrast explicitly.
PM-Bench (Liu & Gabriel, arXiv 2607.12385, Jul 2026)	Prospective memory in agents (acting at the right future time); best about 65% macro F1; reminders trade precision against recall	Medium-high	Our deadline recall (DR) is prospective memory inside a dialogue with a changed dependency. Their over-acting finding parallels our over-intervention cost.
PROPER (Kaur et al., arXiv 2601.09926)	Proactivity as calibration of "unknown unknowns"; fine-tuned dimension generator; no direct intrusiveness measure	Medium	We use prompting only and measure intrusiveness via controls (OVER/NAG).
Do Proactive Agents Need an LLM to Decide When to Act? (Liu et al., arXiv 2605.30152)	A small graph trigger beats LLM self-gating; prompt-only self-gating is worst (−12.7 F1); false alarms stay at 32–49%	Medium	Supports our finding that a prompt alone over-triggers. They use activity logs; we use planning dialogue.
RPCBench (arXiv 2609.00918, Sep 2026)	Proactive premise critique in recommendation; detection is the bottleneck	Medium	Our DCC (untargeted facts) shows the protocol doesn't help detection and may crowd it out.
TREK (arXiv 2607.26977); Trip+ (arXiv 2606.21169); TravelPlanner (Xie et al., ICML 2024)	Travel feasibility, preferences, clarification. Trip+ scores asking but **not proactive disclosure**.	Medium	We score volunteering at decision time, not plan validity.
PROBE, "Beyond Reactivity" (arXiv 2510.19771)	Search, identify, resolve unspecified issues (enterprise)	Medium	Same discovery framing in a different domain; no costs measured.
Proactive Agent (Lu et al., ICLR 2025)	Training agents to anticipate tasks	Medium	We evaluate a prompt protocol, not training.
LLM Judges Verify Presence, Not Absence (arXiv 2608.31016; NeurIPS 2026)	Judges near chance at detecting omissions; per-fact checklists help	**Method**	We use per-field checklists, report per-field judge κ (OVER 0.12–0.27) and a paired human pack with PPI.
LLMs Get Lost in Multi-Turn Conversation (arXiv 2505.06120; ICLR 2026 oral)	Large degradation across turns	Low-medium	Our long-horizon cases probe decay of a disclosed item.
Flout at Your Own Risk (arXiv 2607.11053)	LLMs struggle with pragmatic cooperativity under epistemic asymmetry	Framing	Grice's quantity maxim frames "what to volunteer".

Work	What it shows	Overlap	How we differ
Are Your Agents Upward Deceivers? (arXiv 2512.04864; ICML 2026)	Agents hide failures from supervisors	Low	A different construct (deception about one's own failures).
Horvitz, Principles of Mixed-Initiative UIs (CHI 1999); When Help Backfires (arXiv 2509.09309)	Expected utility of interrupting; unsolicited help can threaten users	Framing	Theory for our over-intervention cost.
Shin et al., ChatGPT for Trip Planning (J. Travel Research, DOI 10.1177/00472875231214196)	ChatGPT narrowing options lowers satisfaction and trust	Framing	Supports "let the user choose" (rule 3).
Prediction-Powered Inference (Angelopoulos et al., arXiv 2301.09633)	Valid inference combining few human labels with many model labels	Method	Our planned judge-bias correction.

3. Claim strength after v0.5 and this sweep

Candidate contribution	Status
"Assistants should volunteer decision-relevant information"	Not novel
"A short instruction increases disclosure"	**Pre-empted in user-service settings** (Thinking Is Not Telling, MASK-OFF). We replicate it across 7 models in long planning dialogues and extend it to timing, silent tradeoffs, deadlines and idle audits.
Decision-time resurfacing after long-horizon decay of a self-disclosed item	Plausibly novel
Silent tradeoff (STR) and idle/slack audit (ISD) as measured constructs	Plausibly novel
Over-intervention and crowding-out costs of a disclosure instruction, with controls built so protocol compliance isn't penalised	**Novel and useful.** Prior work notes intrusiveness but doesn't measure it this way; PM-Bench is the closest parallel.
Explicit state (registry and ledger) adds little beyond instructions	Modest; consistent with PM-Bench's mixed scaffold results
Counterfactual replay of a real failure	Novel as a method; one case

Novelty: about 50/100 (down from 55 after finding "Thinking Is Not Telling"). Position the paper as *timing plus costs*, not as "prompting helps disclosure".

4. What the paper must do

- Cite and contrast "Thinking Is Not Telling", MASK-OFF and PM-Bench prominently in the introduction and related work.
- Lead with the cost result and the timing constructs.
- Present the prompting gain as a replication and extension.